

in the city

interview

'Sufi music is exploited in India'

Delhi-based Sufi singer Zila Husein Khan, daughter of the legendary sitar maestro Ustad Vilayat Khan is promoting her new album—Zila, the girl child. Her previous albums, Zila and Secrets of the Divine, were a hit with those who appreciate classical music. She talks to Shruti Vashist about her new album.

Q. How did you get the name for the album?

A. I am the seventh generation of an unbroken line in what is the oldest school (or gharana) of sitar and surahar in India—the Imdad Khani Gharana. I am the only singer in this gharana. Also, I'm the first woman from my family to have been empowered to sing in public. That's why I'm dedicating this album to women's empowerment. In

it, I have featured only women poets/lyricists and it will be released on March 8, Women's Day.

Q. Tell us about the songs in the album?

A. I have sung the kala of the first Sufi woman, Hazrat Rabia Basri. No one's ever recorded her songs before and I feel blessed to be the chosen one.

Q. What else can we look forward to?

A. There is a lot more coming up, which I can't talk about yet. But I will be doing concerts extensively this year in India. Delhi is waking up to the

difference between a real classical concert and a mere entertainment show, so I am excited about performing here soon. You will also see me singing some hot numbers for films.

Q. Your comment on Sufi music in India?

A. I feel Sufi music in India is exploited a lot. While some sing songs with the words 'Allah' and 'Maula' in them and term them as Sufi music, others who are genuine Sufi singers disguise it as pop or rock music. I am all for fusion, but don't like people singing Sufi under the garb of some other genre because they feel it won't be as popular otherwise. One should have patience. If you are truly good, your music will be recognised.

Q. The best thing you learnt from your father?

A. To play with shrutis (notes). The real depth and emotion of the song comes from there. It's a different world. ■

coming up

Creative act

To celebrate a decade of promoting live and alternative art practices, Khoj, a collective of artists, is curating the first ever International Performance Art Festival in Delhi. To be held from



March 25-30, Khoj Live '08, will be a six-day programme featuring Indian and international performance artists from countries like Germany, France, South Africa, Thailand, Netherlands, Pakistan, Nepal and Indonesia.

Says Parul Wadhwa, programme manager for the festival: "Live Art is not specifically dance, music or theatre. It's more about unrestricted body movements." Call: 65655874 or email at interact@khojworkshop.org for more.

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